



2037 AGE GROUP · AGES 7-9 · FIRST-YEAR GOALIES

BLUE CLAWS GOALIE SYSTEM

Full coaching reference. 11 drills · 4 pods · mastery ladder · 16-week map. Build a brave, talking goalie.

11

DRILLS

4

PODS

8

CARDS

16

WEEKS

STEP

ATTACK THE BALL

Step AT the shot; the “T” with the back foot happens on its own. Coach the attack, not the letter.

L1 · 3

MASTERY LADDER

L1 learning · L2 competent · L3 game-ready. Effort first; numbers only at L3.

TALK

COMMUNICATION COUNTS

Ball Top, Left, Right, Check, Break. A goalie who talks beats one with perfect feet.



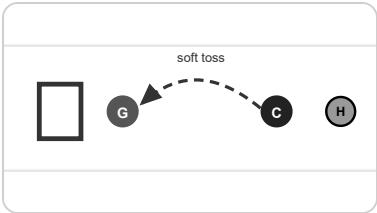
TRACKING & NO-FLINCH

Brave eyes first — and hunt the rebound.

A1

BUCKET TOSS TRACKING

Eyes lock on and follow the ball all the way in. Zero pressure.



GOAL

- Skill: eyes track the ball through the catch
- Why: build tracking confidence early
- Watch: quiet head, no blinking, no turning away

SETUP & BALL

Goalie kneels (no stick) 6–8 ft from coach. Coach underhand-tosses **tennis balls** to the hands/chest, announced every time.

2-PERSON

Backup goalie / parent: shags and refills the bucket, calls “TRACK IT!” every toss, swaps in as kneeling goalie every 10 reps. Nobody idle.

BEGINNER

Soft tosses to the hands, announced. Catch two-handed and say “got it.”

ADVANCED

Vary height; catch one-handed. On a miss, chase the loose ball and scoop it (first rebound hunt).

MASTERY LADDER

L1 · Introduction	Keeps eyes on the ball through the catch, doesn’t turn his head away
L2 · Competent	Tracks and catches calmly without flinching, says “got it” on his own
L3 · Game Ready	Catches ~8 of 10 while stepping to the ball, eyes never leave it

COACHING CUES

EYES IN!

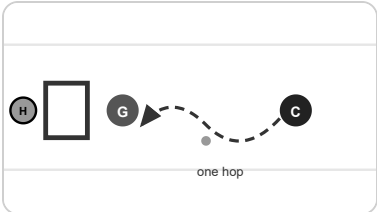
TRACK IT!

HUNT IT!

A2

THE BOUNCE WALL

Get comfortable with a ball moving at him and reacting to a bounce.



GOAL

- Skill: react to a moving, bouncing ball
- Why: comfort with a ball coming at the body
- Watch: steps to it, stick down, body stays square

SETUP & BALL

Goalie in net with stick. Coach 10–12 ft out rolls/one-bounces a **Swax Lax** at the feet and lower body. Low and slow — stepping, not diving.

2-PERSON

Backup goalie / parent: stands behind the net as a “ball stopper” so misses don’t roll away. Rotate goalies every 8 shots.

BEGINNER

Slow ground rolls at the feet. Step and trap, stick head down.

ADVANCED

One-hop bounces to either side at moderate pace. Stick AND body behind it.

MASTERY LADDER

L1 · Introduction	Steps toward the ball instead of standing still
L2 · Competent	Stays square and traps low rolls without backing up
L3 · Game Ready	Handles one-hop bounces both sides, body behind it, ~7 of 10

COACHING CUES

STICK DOWN!

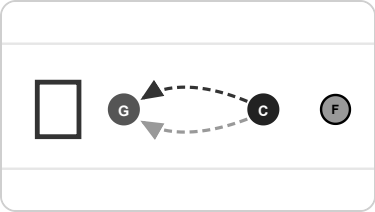
STEP & STOP!

STAY SQUARE!

A3

RAPID-FIRE HANDS

No-flinch reflex — get a stick up fast, repeatedly, eyes open.



- GOAL**
- Skill: quick hands, no-flinch reflex
 - Why: kill the blink before it becomes a habit
 - Watch: eyes stay open, resets between reps

SETUP & BALL
Goalie close, 6 ft, with stick. Coach rapid-tosses soft **tennis balls** to alternating sides. **Chest-height or lower at 6 ft** — a mask shot this close trains the blink.

BEGINNER
3 tosses in a row, slow, announced “right... left... right.”

2-PERSON
Backup goalie / parent: becomes the feeder, handing the coach two balls at a time so the pace never stops. Swap each round.

ADVANCED
5-6 unannounced rapid tosses. Head-height **ONLY** after backing to 10-12 ft. Reset to ready each time.

MASTERY LADDER	
L1 · Introduction	Gets the stick to most balls, eyes stay open
L2 · Competent	No flinch on rapid alternating tosses, resets to ready
L3 · Game Ready	Tracks 5-6 in a row eyes-open, calm hands, ~8 of 10 touched

- COACHING CUES**
- EYES OPEN!
- HANDS UP!
- RESET FAST!

B

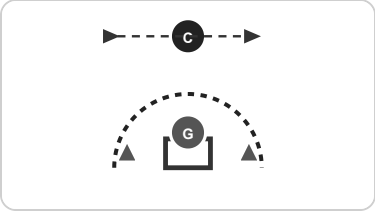
ARC & STEPPING

Attack the ball. The save is the feet.

B1

THE ARC WALK

Stay on the curved top of the crease — always between ball and net.



- GOAL**
- Skill: hold the crease arc, stay square
 - Why: be in the right spot before the shot
 - Watch: feet don't cross, stays square to the ball

SETUP & BALL
Lay 3-5 **cones** in a shallow arc across the top of the crease. No ball. Goalie shuffles cone to cone staying square to a coach walking side to side.

BEGINNER
Slow walk cone to cone, stick up, never crossing feet. Coach calls “left... right...”.

2-PERSON
Backup goalie / parent: stands at the far pipe and points to the coach, giving a target to stay square to. Rotate every 5 trips.

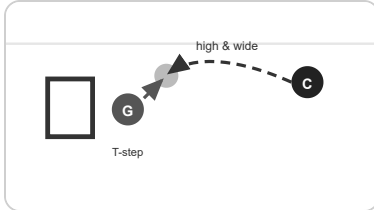
ADVANCED
Coach moves random and faster; shuffle to match, freeze square on the whistle. Remove cones.

MASTERY LADDER	
L1 · Introduction	Shuffles cone to cone without crossing his feet
L2 · Competent	Stays square to a slow-moving coach along the arc
L3 · Game Ready	Matches a faster random-moving coach and freezes square on command

- COACHING CUES**
- TOP OF ARC!
- DON'T CROSS!
- STAY SQUARE!

B2**STEP & ATTACK THE SHOT** STEP

Attack the ball — step toward the shot. The “T” happens on its own when he moves right.

**GOAL**

- Skill: aggressive step toward the ball
- Why: saves come from attacking, not reaching
- Watch: lead foot and hands go AT the ball, nose follows

SETUP & BALL

Goalie in ready stance. Coach 10 ft out calls a side, lobs a **Swax Lax** high and wide. Goalie **steps toward the ball** and drives the hands at it. The back foot forms a “T” naturally — don’t coach the T, coach the attack.

2-PERSON

Backup goalie / parent: drops a cone to the side the goalie should attack, giving a target. Swap shooter/goalie every 8 reps.

BEGINNER

Slow announced lobs to one side. Just step toward the ball, don’t reach from flat feet.

ADVANCED

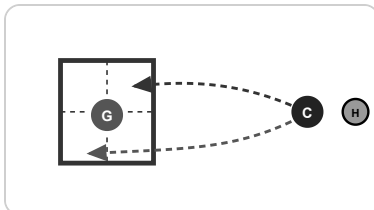
Unannounced high/wide both sides. Hands lead, lead foot drives, save at full extension.

MASTERY LADDER

- | | |
|--------------------------|--|
| L1 · Introduction | Steps toward the ball instead of reaching from flat feet |
| L2 · Competent | Attacks the shot with hands and lead foot on unannounced shots, squares up |
| L3 · Game Ready | Drives to high/wide shots and saves ~half of them, nose to the ball |

COACHING CUES**STEP TO THE BALL!****ATTACK THE SHOT!****PUSH, DON'T REACH!****NOSE TO BALL!****B3****HIGH-LOW-SIDE REACTION**

Match the right move to each of the four save zones, automatically.

**GOAL**

- Skill: pick the right move per save zone
- Why: the body learns where to go without thinking
- Watch: correct move per zone, resets to ready

SETUP & BALL

Goalie in net, stick up. Coach 12 ft out names a zone, tosses a **Swax Lax** there. Step up for high, drop hands for low, step to the ball for wide.

2-PERSON

Backup goalie / parent: calls the zone aloud a half-second before the coach throws, training ears and reaction. Rotate every 10 reps.

BEGINNER

One zone at a time, repeated. Master high, then low, then sides — separately.

ADVANCED

Random zones, no warning. Pick the correct move on the fly, reset to ready.

MASTERY LADDER

- | | |
|--------------------------|--|
| L1 · Introduction | Makes the right move when the zone is called first |
| L2 · Competent | Picks the correct move on most unannounced single shots |
| L3 · Game Ready | Reads random zones and resets each time, right move ~7 of 10 |

COACHING CUES**MATCH THE ZONE!****HANDS LEAD!****BACK TO READY!**



SAVE, REBOUND & WIDE CLEAR

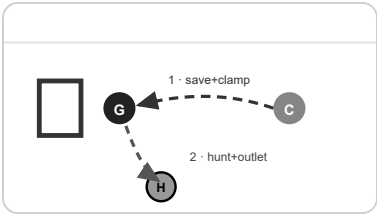
Finish the save and get it out wide.

C1

SAVE, CLAMP & REBOUND HUNT

REBOUND

Secure it — and if it pops loose, attack the rebound instantly.



GOAL

- Skill: secure the save, then hunt loose balls
- Why: the save isn't over until the ball is his
- Watch: clamps it, chases pop-loose, never admires the stop

SETUP & BALL

Goalie in net. Coach lobs a soft **Swax Lax** to the stick — save, squeeze (clamp), cradle. Sometimes the coach throws one that **pops loose**; goalie chases the rebound and scoops it.

2-PERSON

Backup goalie / parent: stands 5 ft to the side as an outlet target; once secured/hunted, goalie tosses to the helper. Rotate every 8 reps.

BEGINNER

Catch and freeze — hold the clamp two seconds, show the ball is secured.

ADVANCED

Mix in pop-loose saves. React to the bounce, scoop the loose ball, then outlet.

MASTERY LADDER

- | | |
|-------------------|---|
| L1 · Introduction | Makes the save and holds it (clamps) instead of dropping it |
| L2 · Competent | Reacts to a pop-loose ball and chases it instead of admiring the stop |
| L3 · Game Ready | Secures or re-scoops ~7 of 10, then outlets, in a live rep |

COACHING CUES

SAVE & SQUEEZE!

HUNT THE REBOUND!

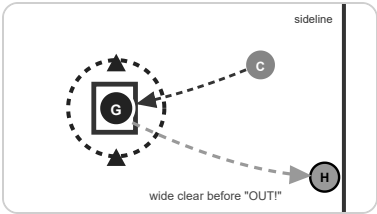
SCOOP & GO!

C2

HOT POTATO WIDE CLEAR

WIDE

Save, beat the 4-second count, clear to the wide sideline alley.



GOAL

- Skill: clear the crease fast and wide
- Why: a save is wasted if the ball stays in the kitchen
- Watch: feet leave the crease, ball goes wide not up the middle

SETUP & BALL

Mark the crease with **cones**; outlet target out near the **sideline**. Coach feeds a **Swax Lax** save. Group counts “ONE-potato... OUT!” Save, step out, clear **wide to the sideline — never up the middle**.

2-PERSON

Backup goalie / parent: is the wide outlet AND the official counter — receives the clear by the sideline, rolls it back. Swap each round.

BEGINNER

Slow count. Just: feet OUT of the crease, ball tossed to the wide side.

ADVANCED

Real-tempo count. Clear the crease AND complete the wide sideline pass before “OUT.” Add a 2nd wide target.

MASTERY LADDER

- | | |
|-------------------|---|
| L1 · Introduction | Steps out of the crease after the save |
| L2 · Competent | Clears toward the wide side before the count ends |
| L3 · Game Ready | Beats the 4-count with a completed wide pass ~7 of 10 |

COACHING CUES

HOT POTATO!

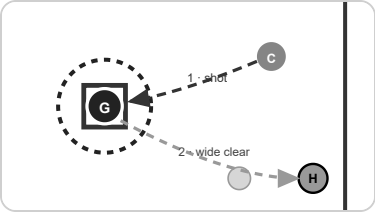
FEET OUT!

CLEAR IT WIDE!

C3

FULL PLAY LIVE REP

Everything at tempo: track, step, save, hunt, wide clear — one rep.



- GOAL**
- Skill: link the whole sequence at game speed
 - Why: real reps tie all the pieces together
 - Watch: completes each step in order under light pressure

SETUP & BALL
Full crease + sideline outlet. Coach takes a light, announced shot. **Real-ball gate: stay on Swax Lax until the goalie catches 8 of 10 without turning his head or closing his eyes** — only then a light real ball. When in doubt, stay soft.

2-PERSON
Backup goalie / parent: plays the outlet attacker breaking to open space near the sideline for the wide pass, then feeds back to the coach. Rotate goalies every 6 full reps.

BEGINNER
Announced medium Swax Lax straight on, one wide target. All steps in order — not speed.

ADVANCED
Light real-ball to varied zones. Read it, step, save, hunt any rebound, clear wide to a moving outlet.

MASTERY LADDER	
L1 • Introduction	Completes save-then-clear in order, slowly, with help
L2 • Competent	Strings track→save→clear together on his own on Swax Lax
L3 • Game Ready	Runs the full play on light real balls, ~half clean, talks through it

- COACHING CUES**
- SEE IT, STOP IT!
- HUNT & CLEAR WIDE!
- WHOLE PLAY!

D

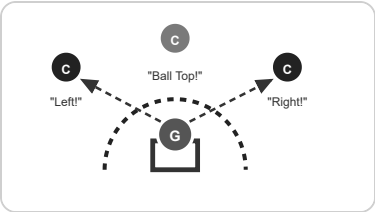
CREASE COMMAND & COMMUNICATION

A goalie who talks beats one who doesn't.

D1

BALL-TOP CALLER TALK

Learn the four basic location calls and say them loud, every time.



- GOAL**
- Skill: call the ball's location — Ball Top, Left, Right
 - Why: a talking goalie is worth more than a quiet one at this age
 - Watch: loud, confident, calls without being reminded

SETUP & BALL
No shots needed at first. Coach (or 2-3 helpers) holds a ball and moves around the top of the box. Goalie points and calls **"Ball Top!"**, **"Left!"**, **"Right!"** as the ball moves. Add **"Check!"** when the coach enters the scoring zone with hands free — a pre-shot readiness cue, not a reaction to the wind-up.

2-PERSON
Backup goalie / parent: acts as a second/third 'attacker' moving the ball, and gives a thumbs-up every time the call is loud enough. Swap the talker every 1-2 minutes.

BEGINNER
Coach moves slowly; goalie calls the spot when prompted ("where's the ball?").

ADVANCED
Coach moves quickly between spots; goalie calls on his own, adds **"Check!"** as the threat forms — feet set, hands free — not at the release.

MASTERY LADDER	
L1 • Introduction	Calls location and "Check!" (as the threat forms, not on release) when prompted by the coach
L2 • Competent	Calls Left / Right / Ball Top on his own as the ball moves
L3 • Game Ready	Talks through most of a moving drill loudly without being told

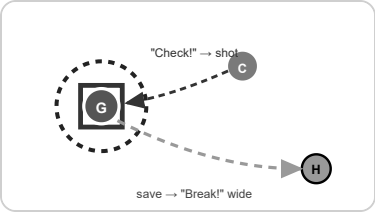
- COACHING CUES**
- BALL TOP!
- LEFT! RIGHT!
- LOUD & PROUD!

D2

SAVE & SHOUT BREAK

TALK

Tie talking to the save — read the threat early, then call the break.



- GOAL**
- Skill: “Check!” on the threat before the shot, “Break!” after the save, “One More!” on a miss
 - Why: links his voice to the action so talking becomes automatic
 - Watch: calls “Check!” as the attacker threatens — feet set, hands free — before the release

SETUP & BALL

Light **Swax Lax** shots. Goalie calls **”Check!”** as the coach steps into shooting position with hands free — before the wind-up — makes the save, then yells **”Break!”** and outlets wide. If a shot misses the net, he calls **”One More!”** to reset the defense.

2-PERSON

Backup goalie / parent: is the outlet who only moves when he HEARS “Break!” — so a quiet break gets no help. Teaches him the voice has a purpose. Rotate every 8 reps.

BEGINNER

Coach prompts each call. Save first, then add the “Break!” shout.

ADVANCED

Goalie calls “Check!” as the threat forms (before release), saves, breaks — full cycle on his own, adds “One More!” on misses.

MASTERY LADDER	
L1 • Introduction	Shouts “Break!” after the save when reminded
L2 • Competent	Calls “Check!” as the threat forms (not on release) and “Break!” after — unprompted most reps
L3 • Game Ready	Reads the threat, calls “Check!”, saves, calls “Break!” (or “One More!”) — every rep, unprompted

COACHING CUES

CHECK!

ONE MORE!

BREAK!

PRACTICE CARD REFERENCES

Grab one before practice. Each runs as a tight station. Combine 2 per session.

1TRACKING12–15 min

DRILLSA1 + A3

FOCUS

SuccessEyes on the ball, no flinch, quick hands

SuccessEyes-open through 5 rapid tosses (A3 L2)

2FOOTWORK & STEPPING12–15 min

DRILLSB2 + B3

FOCUS

SuccessAttack the ball, lead foot drives, square up

SuccessSteps to the ball unprompted (B2 L2)

3ARC PLAY10–12 min

DRILLSB1 + B3

FOCUS

SuccessHold the arc, stay square, don't cross feet

SuccessMatches a moving coach, square (B1 L2)

4HIGH SHOTS10–12 min

DRILLSB2 + B3 (high)

FOCUS

SuccessHands lead up, drive to high/wide

SuccessSaves ~half of high/wide drives (B2 L3)

5LOW & BOUNCE SHOTS10–12 min

DRILLSA2 + B3 (low)

FOCUS

SuccessStick down, body square, handle the hop

SuccessTraps low/one-hop both sides (A2 L3)

6REBOUNDS10–12 min

DRILLSC1

FOCUS

SuccessClamp it, chase pop-loose, never admire

SuccessHunts the loose ball on his own (C1 L2)

7CLEARING12–15 min

DRILLSC2 + C3

FOCUS

SuccessFeet out fast, clear wide, beat the count

SuccessWide pass before 'OUT' ~7/10 (C2 L3)

8COMMUNICATION8–10 min

DRILLSD1 + D2

FOCUS

SuccessLoud calls: Ball Top/Left/Right/Check/Break

SuccessTalks through a rep unprompted (D1/D2 L2–3)

16-WEEK SEASON MAP

Skills build in four phases. Cards refer to the references above.

WK	PRIMARY	SECONDARY	CARDS	BENCHMARK
PHASE 1 · FOUNDATION (NO FEAR, THE ARC)				
1	Tracking (A1)	Arc intro (B1)	1, 3	Eyes stay on the ball, no turning away
2	Tracking (A2)	Arc (B1)	1, 3	Steps toward the ball, stays square
3	No-flinch (A3)	Arc (B1)	1, 3	Eyes open through rapid tosses
4	Stepping (B2)	Tracking review (A2)	2, 1	Steps to the ball, doesn't reach flat-footed
PHASE 2 · STEPPING & SAVES				
5	Stepping (B2)	High shots (B3)	2, 4	Attacks the shot on unannounced reps
6	High shots (B3)	Stepping (B2)	4, 2	Hands lead up on high/wide
7	Low/bounce (A2,B3)	Stepping (B2)	5, 2	Stick down, handles the hop
8	Save & clamp (C1)	Stepping (B2)	6, 2	Holds the save (clamp), no drop
PHASE 3 · REBOUNDS & CLEARING				
9	Rebounds (C1)	Save review	6	Chases pop-loose on his own
10	Rebounds (C1)	Communication (D1)	6, 8	Hunts rebound + says Ball Top/Left/Right
11	Clearing (C2)	Communication (D1)	7, 8	Feet out, clears toward the wide side
12	Clearing (C2)	Communication (D2)	7, 8	Wide pass before the count, shouts Break
PHASE 4 · COMMUNICATION & GAME-READY				

WK	PRIMARY	SECONDARY	CARDS	BENCHMARK
13	Full play (C3)	Clearing (C2)	7	Strings save→clear together on Swax Lax
14	Full play (C3)	Communication (D2)	7, 8	Talks the rep: Check → save → Break
15	Game-ready (C3)	All cards rotate	1-8	Real-ball gate passed (8/10 no-flinch)
16	Game-ready (C3)	Communication (D2)	7, 8	Runs full play on light real balls, talking

PRACTICE SHAPE & BALL RULE

Kids hold focus ~3-4 min per activity. Keep blocks short.

Each session: gear check → tracking (4m) → footwork (4m) → save/clear or comm block (6m) → finish on a mini-game.

Ball rule — earned, not assumed: tennis ball → Swax Lax → real ball, only after the no-flinch gate (8 of 10 caught without turning his head or closing his eyes). When in doubt, stay soft.

SOLO ENGAGEMENT GAMES

No backup goalie? He competes against a number. Under 5 minutes, always ends on a win.

BEAT YOUR NUMBER

Races his own best — the only opponent is yesterday.

- 10 announced soft shots; count every ball he gets a body or stick on (touches count).
- That number is his “record” — write it on the stick tape.
- Beat it by one next time = team cheer.

DON'T WAKE THE DRAGON

The net is a sleeping dragon's cave — keep it asleep.

- Starts with 5 “sleep” points; each save keeps the dragon asleep.
- A goal “wakes” it — lose a point with a fun roar so a goal is silly, not scary.
- Survive 8 shots with points left = tamed it. Then add a wide clear.

Build the **brave kid** first, the goalie second. · Blue Claws Lacrosse · 2037 Age Group